



Primary Open-Angle Glaucoma (POAG)

Glaucoma is a group of eye diseases that can damage the optic nerve, often due to increased eye pressure. Primary Open-Angle Glaucoma (POAG) is the most common form. It usually progresses slowly and painlessly — many people don't notice symptoms until vision loss has already occurred.

What Causes It?

In POAG, fluid inside the eye drains too slowly, leading to gradual buildup of pressure. This can damage the optic nerve over time. Some people develop POAG even with “normal” eye pressure — damage still occurs, likely due to poor blood flow or other factors.

Risk Factors

- Age over 40
- Family history of glaucoma
- African, Hispanic, or Asian descent
- High eye pressure
- Diabetes or high blood pressure
- Long-term use of steroid medications

Symptoms

POAG is often symptomless at first. As the disease progresses:

- Side (peripheral) vision may slowly worsen
- Eventually central vision may also be affected
- If untreated, glaucoma can lead to blindness

Because early stages are silent, regular eye exams are essential.

Diagnosis

Glaucoma is diagnosed with:

- Eye pressure test (tonometry)
- Optic nerve exam (often using imaging)
- Visual field test (to detect vision loss)
- Corneal thickness and drainage angle may also be checked

Treatment Options

While vision loss from glaucoma cannot be reversed, treatment can slow or stop further damage.



Treatment options include:

- Eye drops (first-line): to reduce pressure by decreasing fluid production or improving drainage
- Laser treatment: helps improve drainage
- Surgery: may be needed if drops/laser are not enough

The goal is to lower eye pressure and protect your vision.

Living with Glaucoma

- Take medications exactly as prescribed — they only work if used consistently
- Go to follow-up visits to monitor pressure and nerve health
- Tell your doctor about any side effects or trouble using drops

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: Can glaucoma be cured?

A: There is no cure, but it can often be well-controlled with lifelong treatment.

Q: Can I go blind from glaucoma?

A: If left untreated, yes — but with proper care, most people maintain useful vision throughout life.

Q: Will I need surgery?

A: Most patients do well with drops and/or laser. Surgery is considered if pressure stays high.